The fallout was significant: regulatory scrutiny, damaged brand trust, and a $5.8 million settlement. However, the technical lesson is timeless: Authentication is necessary, but not sufficient. Authorization is what truly protects sensitive data and resources.

As we begin our exploration of authorization in earnest, the Ring case serves as a cautionary tale. It reminds us that verifying someone's identity is only the starting point. The real challenge—and where many systems falter—lies in determining what that person is allowed to do in a given context, at a given time, on a given resource.

4.1 Authorization deserves its own focus

In Chapter 3, we explored the evolution of authentication—from passwords and security questions to biometrics and multi-factor authentication. That discussion culminated with passkeys, a modern, phishing-resistant alternative to traditional methods of authentication that promises to finally break the Internet's dependency on passwords, solving many of the user experience and security problems that passwords have created. With passkeys, the essential building blocks of secure, user-friendly authentication are finally in place. The remaining work will focus on deployment, interoperability, and user adoption. In many ways, authentication has reached a strategic plateau: it's now about operationalizing passkeys everywhere.

Authorization, on the other hand, is just beginning to receive the attention it deserves. While authentication answers the question, "Who are you?" authorization poses a more challenging question: "What should you be allowed to do?" Moreover, whereas authentication is typically a point-in-time event, authorization is continuous, contextual, and often decentralized, making it a more difficult—and more consequential—problem to solve.

Most systems today rely on brittle combinations of roles, hardcoded rules, and permissions scattered across codebases. There's no standardized equivalent to passkeys for authorization. No universal model. No easy button. This makes authorization a fundamentally harder, broader, and more